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What does psychology say about repressing emotions? As a general principle, it is unhealthy. Why? When we hide or repress our emotions, we eventually end up hiding them from ourselves. When that occurs, people around us pick up that which is not said and respond to our conflict with a conflict of their own...It is difficult to stay in integrity when we show one face on the outside and another to ourselves. When this occurs, our work and family suffer. We become ill and our relationships and our results suffer from our dis-ease...

What does science say about repressing emotions? The most recent brain research says that it is impossible. Our emotions cannot really be hidden; they can only be experienced in altered forms. The brain begins to act independent from the immediate situation when it has experienced strong negative emotions in the past. That instinct served us thousands of years ago. It does not work now.

When we repress or hide our emotions, they are expressed in a distorted way.

- ❖ Instead of acknowledging my anger, I may say: "I'm not angry, you're angry."
- ❖ Or, "I'm angry, but you are causing me to be angry."

This process of distorted expression is called projection: I project my feelings or motives into you. I can also become numb or controlling. I can believe that I am making rational decisions, when in fact, I am at the mercy of those emotions that I cannot or will not experience.

Any behavior that is a result of not owning up to an emotion is called a **reaction**. A reaction creates **Backup Behaviors**. Such as defending, denying, justifying, explaining too much, blaming, pretending, avoiding, complicating and more. We become many different versions of our true self, and we do not experience our life as it is. We experience disappointment, resentment, dullness, and others when we are reacting.

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Where does this all distortion come from? Why does it occur? It is the result of adaptation to your family system. It works the same way it does in any system, in any organization. Everyone's parents had to survive and out of this need for survival, their children learned that system. It was created out of a need to be "safe."

In order for leaders to achieve their visions and teams to create synergy within the organizational culture and context, this knowledge needs to be experienced as a natural part of their personal and business models and used as another method of research and data collection.

So what is a mentally healthy, mature, person to do? The answer seems simple enough, yet can be difficult to achieve because of our unconscious needs to see ourselves in a particular way. Very few people are willing to confront and embrace their dark or shadow self. Yet, the healthy answer is to express the emotion in a simple, honest way. This leads to **Flexible Behaviors** and movement toward wisdom. Acknowledge the emotion and understand that, what we feel in the moment is not the "truth," but consciousness information. In addition, the best way to use the information is objectively and neutrally like other data. As an example,

- My boss, peers, friends, lovers, criticizes me. In reaction, I am fearful, angry, and defensive.
- As neutral data, criticism does not threaten my ego. I use the information to meet my larger needs – those of my family, community, business, etc.
- I also learn how to lead more effectively.

Regarding emotions as neutral is another way of saying that the ultimate source of our feelings and thoughts is ourselves, not others, i.e. my boss criticized me, but my subsequent feelings come from me, not the other.

If we experience our emotions neutrally, our responses will change from being programmed and unconscious to being based on present time and vision based. This programming comes out of our

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past relationship with our families or out of ego protection. Instead of having a reactive or programmed response, we have choice. I believe this is "personal responsibility." Personal responsibility is the ability to respond in the moment with unlimited options.

Therefore, in business as in our personal life, having the full range of and expressing our emotions is essential to creating trust, obtaining cooperation, learning to work together as a team, building a sense of common purpose, urgency and results.. The emotional skills — "skills" is not quite right, "self-knowledge" is closer — the emotional skills that are derived from understanding reaction and demonstrating and living from the context of personal responsibility, we call "emotional literacy."

Emotional literacy is the ability and quality of being emotionally literate, especially the ability to "read and write" emotions. A person who is emotionally literate senses and experiences the emotional states of themselves and of others, and is able to express emotions "literally" — that is, without reaction or projection. Generally speaking, emotions in the workplace are still not valued except in the most senior positions.

Knowing where emotions come from, how to experience them neutrally, being able to transform them, and how they advance or hinder all business and personal efforts, make up the skills of **Emotional Mastery**. As this skill is honed and the results of its continued use are experienced, our quality of life and our desired results are enhanced. This translates to a clearer line, a critical path to success and results.

1. Emotion and the Brain features the latest research into emotional expression in the biology of the brain – and its repercussions for the body. New studies are leading scientists to consider that the brain is organized into multiple emotional processing systems, a complex web of connections that handles each emotion separately.